LAUNCH PAD · A GUIDE'S LESSON PLAN BOOK

The Origin Year

Who am I?

A guide's book for Year One of the Launch Pad, written so a learner can read every page.

VIBRANT LIFE

THE YEAR AT A GLANCE

Part 1 - For everyone: what this year is

Part 2 - For the guide: teaching this year

Part 3 - The sessions

1. The Map of Me (four weeks, Aug 16 - Sep 9)
2. The Lineage (five weeks, Sep 20 - Oct 21)
3. The Power of Choice (three weeks, Nov 1 - Nov 18, ends into Thanksgiving)
4. Running My Own Ship (three weeks, Nov 29 - Dec 16, ends into the winter break)
5. The Full Draft (six weeks, Jan 3 - Feb 10)
6. Chapter One (six weeks, Feb 21 - Mar 30)
7. This Is Me / The Unveiling (four weeks, Apr 10 - May 4)

Part 4 - Closing the year

Opening note

This is the guide's book for the first year of the Launch Pad, the year called Origin. It holds the whole plan: the shape of the year, the seven sessions, the week-by-week flow, the things a guide might say, and the ways we keep everyone safe. It is written for the guide to teach from. It is also written so that any learner can pick it up and read the whole thing.

That last part is a rule, not an accident. Here is the rule, and it holds on every page:

> *Everything in this book is safe and honest for a learner to read. Nothing in it manages or manipulates anyone. Lines in "quotes" are things a guide might say aloud. Everything else is for the guide to understand and hold.*

There is no hidden chapter. There is no page that says "here is how to get the reluctant kid to do the thing." A guide's notes here are transparent and kind. If a learner reads a note about themselves, they should feel respected, not handled. That is the whole point of the year, so it is the whole point of the book too.

One author's note on language: this book was written by Erin Stanley, who opened the studio. "The guide" means whoever is leading the studio, and this book says "they" throughout, because that will not always be the same person. "You" sometimes means the guide and sometimes means the learner - the context always makes it clear which.

Part 1 - For everyone: what this year is

The year's question

Origin asks one question, all year: **Who am I?**

That is it. Not "who should you be," not "who do we need you to become." Just the honest, enormous question of who you already are and who you are turning into. Everything this year is a way of walking around that question and looking at it from a new side.

Origin is the first of three years. The three years each carry their own question:

- **Origin - Who am I?** (Know your story.)
- **The Forge - What is worth solving?** (Find your work.)
- **The Helm - What do I do when there is no easy answer?** (Make the hard call, and love the life around it.)

Origin comes first in the telling because a story is the ground the other two years stand on. It is not a prerequisite. The three years turn as a cycle rather than a ladder: whichever year is running when you arrive is the one you start in, and you are not behind. A learner who starts at The Forge asks what is worth solving with the story they already have, and comes to Origin later with more of it. Nobody here is catching up to anybody.

The journey (the year's arc, plain)

The year is built like a story with a beginning, a middle, and an end.

You start by dreaming with no ceiling. You look at where you come from and the people who made you. You practice the muscle of choosing, and then the muscle of running your own days. Then, in the long middle of the year, you write your whole life down, all of it, unedited. After that you become the author of it, shaping it into something you can hold. And at the very end, you make a piece that says "this is me," and you show it to your people.

Named plainly, the seven sessions are:

1. **The Map of Me** - dream 100 dreams and start naming what you want.
2. **The Lineage** - gather the stories of where you come from.
3. **The Power of Choice** - practice choosing on purpose.
4. **Running My Own Ship** - build a routine that fits you.
5. **The Full Draft** - write your whole life, unshaped.
6. **Chapter One** - become the author and shape it.
7. **This Is Me / The Unveiling** - make a self-portrait and show it.

The year rhymes from end to end: you dream it, you draft it, you shape it, you declare it.

The words this book uses

This studio has its own small vocabulary. None of it is a secret, so here it all is, before you meet any of it.

- **A quest.** One piece of work with a beginning and an end: a prompt, an interview, a making, a share. It is the unit you can say no to.
- **A session.** One of the year's seven stretches, each with its own question. Three to six weeks long, with a break after it.
- **The settle.** The three slow breaths that open every guide day.
- **The way down.** Standing up and shaking it out after hard work, so your body can put the stress down.
- **The exit ramp.** The named place you can step out to, without asking, and come back from with nothing said.
- **The closing minute.** The three private questions at the end of an opening. Never written for the studio, never read by anyone.
- **The Work of the Day.** The one piece of the session's work the whole tribe does together that morning, named out loud at the start so you know what the day is for. One per guide day.
- **Your tribe.** The people in this studio with you.
- **The walk-in.** The soft first twenty-five minutes of a guide day, when the door is open and nothing is required. The guide will come to one or two people for a quiet talk inside it. Nothing said in one is written down.

- **The interval.** A your-own day with nothing asked back: one question to carry, nothing to hand in. It is named out loud so you know the quiet is on purpose.
- **The close-return.** The words the room says out loud after a heavy day, so your body hears that the heavy part is over. Always the same words; they are on the settle page.
- **Fallow.** Deliberately empty. Fallow is a farming word: a fallow field is one you leave unplanted on purpose, because that is what makes it rich again. Fridays are fallow, and so is one whole week in the autumn. Never earned, never filled.
- **A harvest.** The last stretch of a session, where you gather what the weeks grew and name what you got. An empty harvest is a real harvest.
- **Witnessed.** Someone was there and saw it. Not watched, not assessed. Being witnessed is a gift and never a demand.
- **A re-thread.** Picking the year back up after a break. The first guide day back starts with it: where were you, where are you now, what came back changed. You are never restarting cold.
- **The pace question.** The guide asking whether the plan still matches the speed your real life is running at.
- **The re-ask.** The guide asking, out loud, *is this still yours?* It means: do you still choose to be here, doing this.
- **Open Waters.** The loose three weeks after the Unveiling: expeditions, your own projects, credit close-out, and real rest.

One word needs a line of its own, because it does two jobs. A **harvest** is the gathering at a session's end, and it is yours. The Vineyard is the one thing in this year that is never harvested, and that is exactly what makes it the Vineyard.

What you make and carry

The Captain's Log. This year you begin one artifact you will carry through all three years: your Captain's Log. It is a record of your own life and your own thinking. You name it yourself. You write in it however you write. It belongs to you, completely. A guide never reads it to grade you or check up on you. The moment a private log becomes something someone else reads to judge you, it stops being yours, and this one stays yours. You will carry it out the door when you leave, and no copy is kept.

The Vineyard. On the very first day, alongside the Log, you name one more thing: a part of your week that is just yours to love. A thing you tend because you love it, and that no one will ever ask you what it was *for*.

What it can be. Almost anything. The list below is deliberately a mess, because there is no right kind of thing:

- an instrument you are slowly getting better at, or one you are not getting better at
- a trail you walk, or a bus route you like riding
- bread. Or a knife you keep sharp, or an engine, or a sewing machine
- a game, including one on a screen
- a friendship you put real time into
- a language nobody in your family speaks
- drawing the same thing over and over
- birds
- a project with no end date and no plan
- lying on the floor and listening to one album all the way through

Some of those sound impressive and some sound like nothing. **That is the point.** This is not a list to choose from, and there is no version of this that counts for more. If your honest answer is the album on the floor, that is a Vineyard, and nobody here will rank it against somebody's violin.

Why this is in a school book at all. The rest of this year asks hard things of you. You will write your whole life down, look at your worst day, and show yourself to a room full of your people. That is one half of what this place is for. The other half is sitting in the third year's question, The Helm: *make the hard call, and love the life around it.* The Vineyard is where that second half lives, starting now rather than in three years. It is not a reward for the hard work, and it is not a break from it. It is the other half of the work, and it is given its own ground precisely so that nothing can quietly turn it into the first half.

It is never made useful. It is never harvested. It is never turned into an assignment. Nobody grades it, reports on it, counts it, or asks you to reflect on it. If a guide ever adds a "Vineyard reflection prompt," the whole thing is dead, so no one will. The moment it becomes useful it stops being a Vineyard.

When, and this is the one part that is required. Making time for something you love is a requirement of this programme. Not a particular thing, not a certain number of hours, and not

anything you hand in. The requirement is that the time is in your week and that something you love is in the time.

That is deliberate, and it is not softness. A life with no un-useful joy in it is not what this place is trying to build you toward, and **finding the time is a skill, exactly like learning to hold your own hours.** Nobody drifts into it. People who have it protect it on purpose, and that is learnable, so we teach it.

In practice: Friday is already yours and is the obvious home. You name a Vineyard-thing in the first week. When you build your routine in Session 4, your Vineyard is in it, and a routine without it is not a finished routine. If your Vineyard-thing needs something that lives here, a workbench or a kiln or a piano or a quiet room, say so in the first week and the door is open to you on Fridays.

And the edge of it, which matters as much as the requirement. Nobody ever checks what you did with the time. Nobody signs in. Nobody is counted. Nobody asks how it went, and that includes the guide. The only question anyone will ever ask is *is the time there* - never what you made, never whether you got better at it, never whether you enjoyed it. It is the same deal as the Table: presence is the whole requirement, never consumption. The moment anyone asks the second kind of question the Vineyard is dead, and the rule against asking it is written as hard as the rules about safety.

The last of the promises says you may refuse the structure itself, and this is part of the structure. So you can refuse this too. What you cannot do is get the programme to stop offering it, or stop protecting the time, or stop asking whether the time is there. **The requirement binds us to keep making room for it. It does not bind you to fill the room.**

The Vineyard is the quiet twin of the Captain's Log. The Log is the self examined. The Vineyard is the self delighted. You carry both from the first morning, and both grow across all three years.

The promises (the six refusals)

Underneath everything, there is a floor of promises. Nothing in the Launch Pad is allowed to break these. In plain words:

1. **No grades or scores anyone but you can see.** Your progress is yours.
2. **No ranking and no leaderboards.** You are never stacked against the person next to you. There is no screen anywhere in the Compass that puts learners side by side. A parent linked to your account can see which of your own goals you have finished, and that is the

whole of what anyone else sees. If that ever stops being exactly true, you will be told before it changes, not after.

3. **No one deposits the answers into you.** You make meaning here; the guide holds questions and walks with you, and does not hand you a finished you.
4. **No imposed deadlines.** You set your own pace. "I didn't get to it" is honored, not punished.
5. **Your worth is not your output.** A quest you abandoned and learned from counts as much as one you finished. Doing more does not make you worth more.
6. **No surveillance.** The data of your life belongs to you, not to the school.

And one more, which sits on top of the six:

You may refuse the structure itself. If you decline a whole quest, you are fully honored. You are not quietly marked down as a failure or an opt-out. Your no is real.

Where your no reaches, and where it stops

Here is the edge of that last promise.

Your no covers your own work. A quest, a prompt, an interview, a share, a whole session, this entire structure. It lands the moment you say it, it costs you nothing, and nobody can overrule it.

It does not cover how you treat the people in the room with you. That is not a deadline and it is not output. It is the floor that makes everything else here safe for six other people, and it is the one place in this programme where something can actually be taken from you. The studio's agreements run that floor, and they have their own ladder. You will meet it in your first week, and you will help write the agreements it rests on. Here is the whole of it, said now rather than when you are standing in it:

- **A Pause.** Step out, settle, come back when you are ready. A council member meets you. The count runs across the day, and a third in one day is a Stop.
- **A Stop.** Home for the day, with a note that goes home and that you fill out with your guide. Stops carry across days.
- **A Strike**, at three Stops. One guide day at home, never your Friday. Your character contract goes home to work on with your family, and when you come back you, your family, Jenna and your guide talk it through. Your Stops reset. A second Strike is at least two guide days, and you come back when you and your family both say the commitment is real.

- **Step Away**, at three Strikes. Not back for the rest of the year, with a real conversation long before anyone is near it, and a way to re-apply the next year.

That is the top of the ladder and the bottom of it. Nothing about it is a surprise, and nothing about it is hidden in a document you are not allowed to read.

So, in one line: **the agreements are about how we treat each other. The promises are about whether you do the work.**

Declining a quest is never a Pause. A Pause is never a judgement on your work, your pace, or whether you are keeping up. If anyone ever runs those two together, they have got it wrong, and you can say so out loud and point at this page.

And if you do not sign. You are in the room anyway, and that was never the price of being here. The agreements still run for you. They are not holding you to your word, because you did not give it. They are holding the room safe for the people in it with you. You can tell us the agreements are not yours. You cannot be outside the floor, because **the floor is not about you.**

How we work: the week

The studio day runs through the morning, 9:00 to 1:00. Across the week, two mornings are guide days and two are your own.

- **Guide days (Tuesday and Thursday).** The guide runs the studio with you. The order of the morning is below, and it is the same every time.
- **Your-own days (Monday and Wednesday).** You run your own morning: your reading, your core academics (the high-school credit work you have claimed, at your own pace), your personal project, and the session's writing. Nobody is steering but you. The guide is in the building, at Vibrant Life Tots with the younger children from 9:15 to 11:30, and then the guide comes to you around noon for a real check-in. Same site, different room. If you need them before noon, you go and get them. You are genuinely running your own hours and you are never actually alone in the building. Both of those are true at once.
- **The fallow day (Friday).** Protected. Never earned, never filled, never converted back into work. It is for rest, play, friendship, and making things for no reason. This is not a reward for finishing. It is practice for a whole life. And it is binding: it does not get eaten to cover a busy week.

A guided morning, start to finish

Guide days run 9:00 to 1:00. The order is the same every single time, so you never walk in wondering what today is.

Time	What happens
9:00 - 9:25	**The walk-in.** Door open, nothing required. Put your things down, make tea, talk or don't. The guide is here and will come find one or two people for a quiet one-to-one.
9:25 - 9:35	**The settle, then the circle.** Three breaths, the same words every time. Then one round of "how are you, really?" You may pass.
9:35 - 10:50	**The Work of the Day.** The session's main work. This is the part that changes week to week. The rest of this table does not.
10:50 - 11:00	**The way down.** Stand, shake it out, step outside, water. Then we eat.
11:00 - 11:40	**The Table.** We eat together. You bring your own lunch.
11:40 - 12:40	**Hands and each other.** Making, cooking, building, fixing, an errand into the world, a project with somebody else. Different from the morning's work on purpose: the body works and the talking gets easy.
12:40 - 1:00	**The close.** One light thing, then your closing minute, then you go.

The times are honest rather than strict. Most days drift ten minutes. The order never drifts.

The Table

Every guide day has a shared meal in the middle of it. Here is exactly how it goes.

You bring your own lunch. On ordinary days the studio does not provide the food.

It is still a shared table rather than a lunch break. We stop, sit down together, and the guide sits and eats with you. The forty minutes is for being a group of people who eat together, not for getting through food on the way to the next thing.

You sit wherever you want. Seats are not assigned, and nobody's seat is kept from last week.

You do not have to eat. Presence is the whole requirement here, never consumption. If you are fasting, or observing, or not hungry, or food is a hard thing for you right now, you sit with us and that is full participation. Nobody watches anybody's plate, and you never owe anyone an explanation for what is or is not on yours.

If you arrive late, come in and sit down. Nothing restarts, and nobody asks where you were in front of the room.

On the two days a year when there *is* shared food, the family-story potluck in the autumn and the feast in May, tell the guide what you cannot eat, once, whenever you know it. Planning around it is the guide's job rather than yours to work around. On those two days the studio provides the base of the meal, and bringing a dish is never required. If you want what the studio brings to stand as yours, say so to the guide once, privately, and it will. Nobody at the table will know the difference, and nobody will ask.

The circle: "how are you, really?"

Right after the settle, every guide day, we go around once. The question is "how are you, really?" and it means the real answer rather than the automatic one.

Here is how it goes. The guide asks, and answers first, honestly and briefly. Then it goes around in order, so nobody is picked on and nobody has to volunteer. One or two sentences each is plenty. "Tired." "Good, actually." "I don't want to say today." Those are complete answers.

You can always pass. Say "pass" and it moves on, with no follow-up and no note taken. Passing is not a smaller answer. A person who passes has been round the circle the same as everyone else.

Nobody fixes what you say here unless you ask. Advice that arrives unasked is not help, so the circle starts from being heard.

But you can ask, and you can ask the room. "Does anyone know what to do about this?" is a completely normal thing to say in a circle, and so is "I just wanted to say it, I don't want to talk about it." Both are answers to the same question, and the question is yours: **do you want this held, or do you want it worked?** Say which and the room will follow you. Six people who know you is not a smaller resource than one guide, and some things a sixteen-year-old knows better than any adult in the building.

If you would rather not ask in front of everyone, that is equally fine. Say so, or say nothing and catch the guide afterwards.

It takes a few minutes. It is not a check-up, and nothing said in it is written down.

Who else is in the room

There are a handful of you and one of me. On guide days my baby is in the studio with us, usually in a carrier on my front. That is the honest shape of this year: you get a guide who is also a parent, in a room where a baby naps and eats and sometimes cries. Some mornings I will be holding a child while we talk.

Two things follow from that, and you should know both before you say yes. First, there will be minutes when my hands are full and the room carries itself for a bit. Second, if you ever need all of me - a hard day, or a conversation that cannot be interrupted - there is a named person who takes the baby. Then I am entirely yours. That handoff is arranged before the year opens. It is not improvised on the day.

Arriving late, stepping out, coming back

Arriving late. Walk in. There is no procedure and nothing restarts. If the circle is going, join where it has got to, or pass. If the settle is going, sit down and pick it up on the next breath. Nobody will ask you in front of the room where you were. If something made you late and you want the guide to know, catch them at the Table.

Coming back after stepping out. The soft parts of the day are named so you know where the easiest way back in is: the walk-in, the Table, and the hands block after it. You can come back at any moment, including the middle of a hard one. The soft seams are just the ones where nothing has to be said at all. Nobody says anything to you when you come back. Not even "glad you're back." You pick up a plate or pick up a tool and you are in.

The Log, captured however you hold it

You keep the Captain's Log in whatever form is true to you. Written in a notebook. Spoken aloud and recorded. Drawn. Dictated. Typed. Told to a scribe who writes it down for you. No form is the lesser Log. The point is that you are keeping your own record, not that it looks a certain way.

Where it lives. Your Log can go home with you, or stay here somewhere only you open, or both, and you can change your mind any time. If you want it to stay here, say so and nobody asks why. It is not kept in the Compass or on any school computer, and no copy is made, because the moment there is a copy somebody else is holding your life.

When you write in it. There is no Log time and nobody will ever call one. Here is where the room has room for it, and all of these are open rather than expected:

- **The walk-in**, the first twenty-five minutes of a guide day. Nothing is required then, so if you came in with something on your mind, that is the place to put it down before the day starts asking things of you. Some people need to write before they can talk, and the walk-in sits before the circle on purpose.
- **Right after your closing minute**, at the end of a guide day. This is the natural one. The closing minute hands you exactly the kind of thing the Log is for, and you are already quiet and already finished. Some people say the three answers under their breath and then write them down; some write something else entirely; some write nothing.
- **Your own mornings**, Monday and Wednesday. Your block, your call, no check-in about it.
- **Friday**, if you want it. Friday is also a fine day to deliberately not write. A record you have to feed every day stops being a record and becomes a chore, and **there are supposed to be days you skip.** Weeks, even. A Log with gaps in it is not a failed Log; it is what an honest one looks like.

One rule about this, and it is for the guide as much as you: **nobody writes on a bell.** We will never all sit down and write at the same time, because the moment that happens, everyone can see who is writing and who is not, and the only thing that makes this yours is that nobody is watching. Your Log is private in what it says and private in whether you touched it today.

How "no" works here

You may decline anything. **Your no takes effect the moment you say it, and it is not conditional on explaining yourself.** This is called **decline-with-reasoning**.

You can say no to any quest, any prompt, any interview, any share, and the no lands straight away. Nothing is held up while you find words.

The reasoning is still owed. Two things about that, and they matter equally. **It is owed to your tribe, not to the guide** - you are in a room with other people whose work and plans move around yours, so they get to know where you stand. It is not a toll you pay an adult for permission. And **it is not owed in the moment.** "I don't know yet, and I'll come back to you"

is a real answer. Take a day. Take the week. Work it out in your Log first and come back when you have it. A reason you had to produce on the spot is not thinking, it is pressure.

The guide may ask you an honest, curious question about it, the way a friend might. But the guide **has a voice, never a veto.** The guide cannot overrule your reason, and cannot require you to have one ready. The question is a mirror, not a test you can fail.

There is one place where even the curious question is set aside: anything to do with official papers and government forms. There, an honest reason for declining might reveal something private about your legal situation that a guide has no business knowing. So on that one surface, your no needs no reason at all.

The settle

Every guide day opens with a short, body-first way in, and there is a matching way down when something gets heavy. This is fixed, and it is yours to keep for life.

- **The way in (the Settle).** Three slow breaths with the out-breath longer than the in-breath (roughly four counts in, six counts out), feet flat, one hand where you feel your breath. The guide paces it out loud, the same way every time. The out-breath is what tells your body it is safe to settle. No app, no playlist, no special frequency. Just a human voice, used the same way on purpose.
- **The way down.** After hard work stirs the body up, you stand, shake it out, take a short walk, move the activation *through* the body before sitting back down. If standing or walking is not yours, any movement that is - shaking out your hands, rolling your shoulders, rocking - does the same work. A body cannot work off a stress spike sitting still. This is thirty seconds to a few minutes, and it comes before the shared meal, because a body still buzzing cannot take a meal as welcome.
- **The way out (the exit ramp).** There is a named place you can step out to, set up in the first week. You do not have to ask. And there is a designed way back in during a soft part of the day, with no scene, no acknowledgment demanded. Stepping out and coming back costs you nothing. This is the room holding a door open for you, never the room watching you for a fall.
- **The way back (the close-return).** After a day that went somewhere heavy, the room says out loud that the heavy part is over, so your body hears it and not just your head. These words do not change either:

> SAY
>
> "That was then. This is now. Look around and name one thing you can see. You're in this room, and the hard part is behind you."

It sounds almost too simple to do anything. It works because a body that has been inside a hard memory for an hour does not automatically notice that the hour ended, and being told, in words, is how it notices. Solo version, for the rest of your life: *that was then, this is now, and I'm here.*

The closing minute

At the close of an opening - a dream named, a memory touched, a hard thing looked at - you take a quiet minute and cross back through three fixed questions. They are always the same, in the same order:

1. **What did I meet?**
2. **What do I carry back?**
3. **What's different in me now - even a little?**

That is the whole practice. It is spoken or held in your head, never written down for the studio, never read by anyone. It is yours.

Reach for the real answer. Taking the first thing that comes to mind and moving on makes this worth almost nothing. Staying in the question for a whole minute and letting something come up makes it worth a great deal, and **something almost always comes up, if you stay open long enough to hear it.** That takes a kind of nerve. It is the same nerve the rest of this year asks for, and it is the part of this practice that actually changes people. Going toward the hard thing on purpose is the whole skill.

"I don't know yet" is a real answer - not because the question has no answer, but because sometimes the true one has not surfaced, and naming that beats manufacturing something to have said. "Nothing's different, and I'm steadier for having looked" is also true and complete, because steadier is a change.

Nobody reads this, nobody asks about it, and no one can tell from the outside whether you reached or shrugged. **This is the one practice here that runs entirely on your own honour.**

The reason this exists: the year opens a lot of doors inside you. This is how you learn to close them yourself, so that when you are grown and something cracks you open, you already know

the way home. The measure of it working is not a good answer. It is that you still use it years from now.

The one adult outside the room

There is one adult, outside the studio, you can always talk to. You will know who they are and how to reach them in the first week, before you ever need them.

A line about breaks. When the studio is on a break - the short ones between sessions, Thanksgiving, the two weeks at winter, and the summer - the guide is not reachable. A break is rest and reset for them too, and the book protects that the same way it protects your Friday. Two things stay open the whole time:

- **The one adult outside the room**, reachable across every break, the same as always.
- **988**, free, open all day and all night, call or text, from anywhere.

Nobody here will ever be upset that you used either one.

And this is the shape of privacy here, told to you on the first day rather than in the moment it starts to matter. Almost everything stays here. Your Captain's Log, nobody reads. Your closing minute is never written down by anyone.

Here is what doesn't. If the guide believes you are in danger, that someone is hurting or neglecting you, or that something is going on that is bigger than a studio morning can hold, they will bring in real help. That includes:

- talk of suicide or self-harm
- abuse or neglect
- something going wrong with eating
- a crisis with drugs or alcohol
- a panic or a flashback they cannot reach you through
- a threat to someone else
- something that keeps going and is getting in the way of your life

Those are two different things and they have different consequences, so both get named. **Abuse or neglect is a report**, and in Idaho the guide is required by law to make it. **Everything else on that list is a hand-off**, which means they stop the session work and help you get to someone trained, you will be told who, and you get a say in which one and when.

In most of those cases they will also call your parent or guardian, and they will tell you they are making the call. The one exception is if your parent or guardian is the person hurting you. Then the call goes to the state rather than to them.

That is the whole list. It is not one secret trapdoor, and the guide will never go looking for a reason to use it. **What they know is only what you chose to tell them.** None of this is breaking trust. It is what care actually looks like.

What gets written down about you

Short answer: very little, and you can read all of it.

- **Your Captain's Log and your Vineyard.** Yours. Nobody reads them. No copy is kept.
- **Your closing minute.** Never written down at all, by anyone.
- **Your witnessed work** - your dreams list, your Chapter One, your portfolio, your This Is Me piece. The guide sees what you bring into the room, and so do the people you choose to show. That is what bringing it means.
- **The guide's own notes.** A short practical record: attendance, your pace and your credit plan, and a factual note if there is ever a safety event, meaning what happened, what they did, and who they called. A safety note never contains what you wrote or said about your own life.
- **Your Growth Record, in the Compass.** The one record here that is built to leave with you. It works differently from everything else on this list, so it has its own section below.
- **The agreements record, if you ever reach a Stop.** Our studio agreements run on a ladder: a Pause, then a Stop, then a Strike. The Stop and the Strike are the two rungs that make paper. A Stop note says what happened and goes home the same day, you fill it out with your guide, and the line about coming back is yours in your own words. A Strike letter lists the dates of the three Stops. Your character contract is yours, in your handwriting, and a copy stays with Jenna while you are working it. All of it records a choice and never a judgement about who you are, the count clears at the start of each year, and none of it goes on a transcript or travels with your Growth Record.
- **What is never kept.** Scores. Rankings. Assessments of your character written by anyone but you. Any note about you that you have not read. Any file that follows you past this year.

You can ask to read anything written about you, at any time, and the guide will show you. If you think a note is wrong, say so, and it gets corrected. That includes a Pause, a Stop or a

Strike: if you think a call was wrong, say so, and it can come off - off the note and off the count. You do not have to be calm about it. A learner who is angry at an unfair call is giving us information, not failing a condition.

That is the whole of it. "No surveillance" is a promise about this list, and the list is short on purpose.

The Growth Record, and whether any of this counts on paper

You are sixteen to eighteen, so a fair question about any year of your life is whether it counts on paper.

The Compass holds a record called your **Growth Record**, and the whole design of it is that you own it and the studio does not. The app is a lens, not a vault: you hold the keys from the first day, and a guide is a guest whose access ends when the relationship does. A school cannot lose, withhold or hold hostage a record it never held in the first place.

It has two faces, and you control which one anybody sees.

- **The Journey view** is the whole trail, in order, with the slow parts and the stalls in it. It stays private. It is yours.
- **The Portrait view** is the one you would hand a college, an employer or a programme. It is framed as what you can actually do, and **you choose what goes into it, piece by piece.** Nobody assembles your Portrait for you, and nobody sends it anywhere without you.

One rule holds across both, and it is built into the thing rather than promised about it: growth here is only ever shown as **movement compared to your own earlier self.** Never a grade. Never a score. Never set beside another learner.

And the honest limit, which you should hear from us rather than discover. The part that lets the record physically leave - a real export, readable by a human, held in your hands - **is not finished yet.** It is being built. Until it exists, nobody walks the Launch at the end of the three years, because a ceremony that hands you something that is not there is not a ceremony. That is a rule the programme put on itself before any learner was in the room.

Two more things. High-school credit is tracked separately, and it is the one record other people read as a routine matter, which is the honest exception to the first promise. And a transcript from a studio like this one is not yet a thing every college recognises; the bridge to dual enrollment is real work and we will do it alongside you rather than pretending it is already finished.

Part 2 - For the guide: teaching this year

The shape of the year, and naming the destination on day one

Origin runs the full Vibrant Life year, mid-August to late May, and it runs on the school's calendar rather than a tidy one of its own. Seven sessions with a break between each: thirty-one weeks of session work, plus the three-week Open Waters tail, for thirty-four program weeks in all. The sessions are **not** equal lengths. They are set by where the breaks fall.

Origin 2027-2028. A program week is Monday to Thursday. For the Launch Pad that means two guided mornings (Tuesday and Thursday), two the learners run themselves (Monday and Wednesday), and Friday fallow.

Session	Dates	Weeks
S1 The Map of Me	Aug 16 - Sep 9	4
session break	Sep 13 - 16	
S2 The Lineage	Sep 20 - Oct 21	5
session break	Oct 25 - 28	
S3 The Power of Choice	Nov 1 - Nov 18	3
Thanksgiving	Nov 22 - 26	
S4 Running My Own Ship	Nov 29 - Dec 16	3
Winter break	Dec 20 - 31	
S5 The Full Draft	Jan 3 - Feb 10	6
session break	Feb 14 - 17	
S6 Chapter One	Feb 21 - Mar 30	6
session break	Apr 3 - 6	
S7 This Is Me / The Unveiling	Apr 10 - May 4	4

Session	Dates	Weeks
Open Waters (flex tail)	May 8 - May 25	3

Four Mondays inside sessions are holidays: Labor Day in S1, the second Monday of October in S2, MLK Day in S5, and Presidents Day on S6's first day. A Monday here is a self-run morning rather than a guided one. The October holiday is Columbus Day on the federal calendar and Indigenous Peoples' Day by this programme's values; S2's watch-fors hold the naming. Two guide days in S3 are holidays too, Election Day and Veterans Day; whether the studio observes them is decided before S3 opens. Each session's spine line in Part 3 carries its own. Nothing spans the winter breaks: S3 ends into Thanksgiving and S4 ends into the winter break, which is a real teaching and staffing fact you plan around rather than through.

Every session ends into a break, so every session carries the same two seams. On the last guided day, the carry-out: the pace question, the harvest, and the closing minute at session scale. On the first guided day back, the re-thread. The re-ask is rarer and is asked three times, where there is still time to act on the answer: at the winter break, after the Full Draft, and on the year-close day. The agreements are open for reopening at every session's close too - say so on the last guided day, every time, so the handle is real and not only promised in week one.

The break dates above are projected from the school's 2026-2027 calendar, which ran 17 August to 27 May with the same shape. Jenna sets the real ones; confirm before anything is printed for a family.

On day one, name the destination out loud. Say it plainly in the first week:

> SAY
>
> "In May, you'll show your people who you are - as much of it as you choose. We call it the Unveiling. Everything between now and then is getting ready to mean it."

The mountain should be visible from the trailhead. A learner walks a long arc better when they can see where it is going.

The safety floor

You are running an examined-life year with teenagers, so the floor under it has to be real, seeded early, and grown as the year deepens. Four pieces:

The settle, the way-down, and the exit ramp. Described in full in Part 1 (the learner reads the same words you do). Teach them in the first week, with the framing that they are the learner's

for life. **Fix your own wording for the settle in the first week, write it down, and then do not improve it.** If it starts feeling stale to you, that staleness is the thing working: it is stale to you because it has become automatic for them, which is the entire goal. Keep them fixed - same cadence, same anchor, same spoken cue, every guide day. The sameness is the medicine; a settle improvised freshly each day never becomes the reflex a body can drop into without thinking. Anchor the way-down especially at Session 5, where writing a whole life will activate bodies.

The closing minute. Also in Part 1. Teach it light and concrete in Origin. Model it out loud a few times, genuinely, then get out of the way and let it become the learner's private reflex. Name the close; never demand the content. "Take your closing minute" is the whole prompt.

How to push the reach when you cannot see the answer. This is the one practice you are asked to raise the bar on and are structurally unable to audit, so the pushing has to happen before the minute rather than after it. Two things do all the work.

Model a hard one out loud, early, and let it be slow. Not a tidy one. Do your own closing minute in front of them in the first weeks, including the part where you sit for twenty seconds and have nothing, and then say the thing you actually found. A learner who has watched an adult stay in a question past the comfortable point knows what reaching looks like. One where the adult always had a neat answer ready learns that the practice is a performance with a right length.

Put the standard in the invitation, never in the follow-up. "Take your closing minute" stays the whole prompt on the day. The place to say *go for the real one, something almost always comes up if you stay open long enough* is when you teach the practice, and at a session's close when you are talking about the practice rather than collecting its answers. Say it to the room, about the practice, never to a person about their minute.

And hold the line that makes the bar possible: **you still never ask what came up.** A raised bar with an audit attached is not a higher standard, it is a graded reflection, and the learner will start producing answers for you. The honour system is not the weak version of this. It is the only version that survives them leaving.

The circle, and holding "ask the room." Described in full in Part 1. One round, in order, pass always allowed, and you answer first so the register is set by you rather than by whoever is bravest. The part that needs your hands is the asking. A learner can ask the room for help with what they just said, and the room is often better at it than you are, so the work is not to answer first. It is to make sure the asking stays the learner's.

Three moves, and they are the whole job:

- **Default to held.** If nobody asked, nobody advises. When a learner says something hard and the room starts solving, stop it once, warmly, and out loud: "Hold on. Did you want ideas, or did you just want to say it?" Then do whatever they answer. Asking that question in front of everyone teaches the room the rule faster than any explanation.
- **Hand the room the question, not the answer.** When a learner does ask, your first move is "who's got something for that?" rather than your own best thought. You speak last or not at all. A guide who answers first has quietly told six people their experience is the backup option.
- **Close it when it is done.** Advice has a natural length and teenagers will overshoot it out of goodwill. "That's a good place to leave it, thank you" is the whole intervention, and it protects the person who asked from a room that is enjoying helping.

And watch the one that will actually happen: the learner who asks for help every single morning. That is not a circle problem, it is a learner telling you something, and it belongs in a walk-in rather than in a rule that narrows the circle for everybody.

When to reach for outside help (the referral pathway). You are a life-coach and mentor, not a licensed clinician. Sessions surface identity, memory, grief, and hard days by design, so clinical material will come up. Your job is not to treat it. It is to recognize it, hold the moment safely, and route it to real help fast.

Route now. Do not "work it in a session." Route if you see or hear any of these:

- any mention of suicide, self-harm, or not wanting to be here
- abuse, neglect, or someone hurting them
- a crisis happening right now: panic, a flashback, feeling cut off from their own body, or distress you cannot reach
- signs of something going wrong with eating
- a crisis with drugs or alcohol
- a threat to someone else
- something past an ordinary hard day: it keeps going, and it is getting in the learner's way

When in doubt, route. Being sure is a clinician's job, not yours.

In the moment:

- Stay with the learner. Never leave them alone in a crisis.

- Move to the quiet space you set up before the year opened. A real room or corner, not a hallway.
- Be present, calm, and listening.
- Do not fix it, do not ask for details, do not counsel.
- Do not promise secrecy you cannot keep.

Then name your own honest limit out loud. One guide has only so much capacity to hold a breakdown and the whole room at the same time. That limit is real, not a failing. It is exactly why there is a named list of trusted adults who can step in when you cannot hold both.

The second pair of hands. That list has one more line on it that must never stay blank: the person who takes the baby. A name, a current number, and a confirmed answer to "can you be here inside twenty minutes on a Tuesday morning." Read the instruction above again. "Stay with the learner and never leave them alone" and "move to the quiet space" both assume two free hands, and on guide days the baby is worn. Both things are true, and they are only both true at once if somebody else can arrive. If nobody can, the crisis plan is not built yet, whatever else is on the roster.

Two duties you cannot coach around, in Idaho.

Someone is in immediate danger. Call or text **988** (free, 24/7; chat also works). If it is life-threatening, call **911**.

You suspect abuse, neglect, or abandonment of a child. In Idaho everyone is a mandatory reporter, and that includes you. Report it, ideally within 24 hours. You do not need proof.

- Statewide: **855-552-5437**
- Treasure Valley: **208-334-5437**
- Or **2-1-1**, or local law enforcement

If the parent or guardian is the source of the harm, that is a report, not a phone call home.

This duty does not give you a key to the Log. You do not read it, so it cannot be a source. What the duty reaches is what a learner tells you, shows you or hands you, and what you see and hear in the room. Say that distinction out loud on day one: the Log is never read, and what you are told, you may have to act on. Going looking is the one thing that is never true.

Build the referral roster real before opening - names and current numbers, not categories. The one line that must never stay blank is a named, warm-referral therapist: one or two local licensed clinicians the studio can send a learner to, arranged before the year opens. "Route to

real help" is only real if there is a real person to route to. The pathway runs across breaks, not only on program days, and the learner is told so before each one.

Keep confidences safe. Almost everything a learner writes and says here is theirs. Say so, up front, on day one, woven into the promises you make each other on day one:

> SAY
>
> "Almost everything you write and say here is yours. Your Captain's Log, nobody reads - including me, and I won't go looking. What I can't keep private is a short list, and I'd rather you hear it now than find out later: if you're in danger, if someone's hurting you, or if something's going on that's bigger than I can hold here. That's when I bring in real help, and usually that means a call home too. I'll tell you when I'm doing it. That's not breaking trust - it's what care actually looks like."

Those are the same promises that are on the learner's privacy page in Part 1, in your own voice. Say them in these words, rather than improvising a warmer version. A learner who hears a different wording than the one they read goes looking for the seam.

A confidentiality limit named up front is a promise kept. Named in the moment, it feels like betrayal. Say it before it is ever needed.

Holding a "no"

Decline-with-reasoning lives or dies in the single moment a learner actually says no. If that moment collapses into invisible opt-out - silence, the activity just continues around them - the learner is protected by being erased from the room. So hold a no in three beats, and you can run them under load:

1. **Receive the no, whole.** "Okay. You're not doing this one." Honor it *before* any curiosity, so your curiosity never lands as a lever.
2. **Offer the door once, and don't push it.** "That no stands, and it's done. When you've worked out what's behind it, the tribe will want to hear it. Not me - them. And not today." Hold both halves or you have turned the practice into a toll: the reasoning is genuinely owed to the room, and it is genuinely not owed in the moment. If a learner never comes back to it, that is between them and the tribe, and it is not yours to collect.
3. **Keep them inside the encounter.** "Come sit with me - you don't have to do the thing." Removing the task is not the same as removing the person.

Your question stays a mirror. It is never a way to scare someone into yes.

Ask this: *"When do you think you'll first run into this for real?"*

Do not ask this: *"What happens the first time you need this and no one is beside you?"*

The first one opens a door. The second one pictures the learner alone and unready, and a worried learner hears it as "you'll be sorry."

And whether a fear is the useful kind is the learner's to name about themselves. It is never yours to assign. The instant you re-code a reasoned no as "avoidance" so you can override it, you have smuggled the veto back in as a diagnosis. You have a voice. You never have a veto.

Watch-fors, and protect yourself

You are the floor everyone else stands on. That is not a self-care footnote; it is safety instrumentation. Co-regulation is a physiological output - you spend your own steadiness to settle a flooded learner, all day. A depleted guide cannot run the watch-and-pivot the whole floor depends on. So:

- **Run your own settle, your own way-down at day's end, and your own closing minute.** Your regulation is part of the design, not an extra.
- **Your fallow day is fallow too, and so are the breaks.** Protected, not on-call. Do not eat them to cover a hard week. The learner's page says plainly that you are not reachable over a break, so you never have to improvise that limit on the last guided day; what you say aloud before each break is who is: the one adult outside the room, and 988.
- **Debrief what you witness, more often than monthly.** Holding teenagers' worst days and self-portraits is a real load. After any safety event, debrief with a peer or supervisor and do not carry it alone. Document incidents factually and minimally (what happened, what you did, who you contacted), never the learner's private content.
- **A pre-committed pause trigger.** If the deep work has been set aside two guide days in a row (from exhaustion or from a hard week), pause to a lighter mode and re-plan rather than push through. Commit to this now, while rested. A depleted person does not pause on instinct; that is exactly when the instinct fails.
- **Permission, in writing.** A deep block you set aside, or a good-enough December day, is the design working, not you failing. This is the Origin year, not a mastery year. The permission the learners get, you take too.

Two general watch-fors across the year. Guard against any framing that turns a learner's life into a map of what is missing in them: the quiet region is an invitation, not a deficit. And feelings are your private hope for a learner, never the session's aim. You cannot schedule

"being seen" for a Thursday. Each session has a kind of gladness we hope for. Word it as a possibility - some feel it, some feel nothing yet, both are true - never as the outcome you are delivering.

Part 3 - The sessions

Each session below has the same seven parts: what it's for, a short intro the learner reads, the flow week by week, things to say, the settle plus the closing minute, watch-fors, and what you'll need. Three sessions carry one more block in the same place, after the things to say: Session 1 (inside the dream session), Session 3 (the choice games) and Session 7 (the year-close). Each is one piece of a session too big for a week line. The day-shapes are the same all year (guide days Tuesday and Thursday; your-own days Monday and Wednesday with a midday check-in; Friday fallow), so the flow sections describe what changes, not the fixed grid.

The weeks inside a session follow one small grammar, and the word in brackets after each week says which beat it is: a session **opens**, **deepens**, **applies**, and **harvests**. A five-week session adds a **gather**, the week the work leaves the room and comes back. A three-week session doubles up. Session 2 gives its deepen week to the field and calls it what it is: fallow.

One word about words. Part 1 said the Log is kept however you hold it, and that holds all year. When the sessions below say write, draft, page, or read, they mean put it in your Log and go back to it, in whatever form yours takes. The book says write because it is the shortest word, not because it is the only way. And anything the room listens to has a transcript in the room; anything the room reads can be heard. Both are on the table for everyone before anyone needs them; nobody has to ask.

Session 1 - The Map of Me (four weeks, Aug 16 - Sep 9)

What it's for: to dream with no ceiling and start naming what you actually want.

For the learner: This is where you get to find out how much bigger your life might be than you have let yourself imagine - some people are startled by their own list, some are not yet, and both are true - and where you start naming it out loud. You are going to write a hundred dreams. Not the realistic ones - all of them. Then we look at what they say about you. This is

the "first creation": you dream a thing before you build it, and everything the next years build, you dream here first.

The flow:

Weeks 1-4 · Aug 16 - Sep 9 · off: Mon Sep 6, Labor Day

- **Week 1 - the threshold week (open).** The whole first week is the crossing, and the order is the point. Agreements signed in the hour you met the room are compliance, not consent, so this week gives each rite its own air. **Tue: arrival, then the door.** The walk-in, the opening circle with the first "how are you, really?", a name round (pass is always allowed), the Table, the map of the year. Then **the exit ramp is built and walked, before any promise is asked for** - show them how to leave, let them use it once in practice. A no with nowhere to stand is a courtesy, not a right. Then the privacy words from Part 2, said as written and not warmed up - the room is honest about its limits before it asks for anything - and the name of the one adult outside the room, and how to reach them. **All of it carried on a shared task**, something to do side by side; seven strangers put in a circle to name themselves with no work under it feels like exposure, not welcome. **Wed is the interval**, which means a day where nothing is asked back. The promises have been offered - the six refusals and the one that sits on top of them - and nothing is owed in return yet. **Thu: the tribe's own half.** Say the floor before they start writing: there are six things this tribe cannot agree to, and they are the six they were promised. An agreement that makes doing the work, finishing, keeping pace, hitting a date or sharing a piece enforceable is not theirs to write, because a ladder would then stand behind it. The learners co-write their own agreements (contributions can be written on a card, not only spoken), and the agreements are named as **reopenable** - say when, in words rather than in principle: at any session's close, and on request at any walk-in. Agreements you can sign only once are a door with no inside handle. Say also what happens if a learner will not sign: they are in the room anyway. The agreements describe how we treat each other. They were never a condition of being let in. Then, last and separate, the carried objects: name your Captain's Log, with every form it can take out on the table so picking one says nothing about you, and name your Vineyard-thing. The first Log entry is theirs to make whenever the walk-in or the close gives them room for it - nobody writes on a bell, and that is true from the first week. **At the very end of the week**, send home the 100 Dreams assignment.
- **Week 2 (deepen).** They arrive on the first guide day *with* their dreams - a full week of collecting, so the ones that arrive late are in the list. Run the dream session (below). The

first solo day is narrated so the shape is visible. The second guide day goes deeper: what do your 100 dreams say about what you actually want? *Keep this week and the next side by side on shared, comparable material: first-week impressions - the funny one, the quiet one - are still loose here, and common work keeps them loose. Nobody is assigned a part and nobody is moved out of one; the material is kept shared so each person has room to be more than their first morning.*

- **Week 3 (apply).** Sort the dreams by time horizon (within 12 months / one to five years / five-plus years) and notice what the shape reveals. Then map them across the five regions of the Compass the learner already navigates - Self, Others, Making, World, Voice - using warm prompts so no part of life gets missed. The credit and path conversation begins this week, warmly, in walk-ins and check-ins - never as a day-two audit.
- **Week 4 (harvest). Tue: the courage pass** - "which of these scares you a little?" **Wed is the interval again, and it is named out loud as one**: the learners run it themselves, carrying one question and handing in nothing. Late in S1 they can hold their own silence, which they could not on Day 1. **Thu: each learner picks three within-12-months dreams** as the session's orienting goals - a commitment decided after a night and a day of their own air, not in the hour the courage was spent. Three is the shape, not a gate - a learner who can name one, or none yet, has harvested truly. Ask the pace question as the day closes: is the plan matching the speed that is real for you right now? Run the closing minute at session scale, the first time at that size. Then the session closes and bridges to The Lineage, and the ten-day break lets the goals rest. (Labor Day removes this week's Monday, a self-run morning.)

Things to say:

> SAY
>
> "Your first quest, before Tuesday: write 100 dreams. No filter, no ceiling, nothing has to be realistic, don't edit a single one. You'll hit a wall around 40 where the easy ones run out - that's exactly where the real ones start, so keep going. Bring your list Tuesday and we'll dig into them together. A hundred is the target, not a gate - bring what you've got."

> SAY
>
> "The Compass is how you read your sky; the Log is how you steer - same voyage. You'll navigate by the chart you're building right now."

> SAY
>
> "If you hear a dream you want, add it to your own list. Borrowed dreams count."

> SAY
>
> "A thin region isn't a lack - it's a door you haven't walked through yet. You don't have to. If you're curious, what's on the other side of it?"

> SAY
>
> "Any of these can change, or be dropped, or outgrown at any point, with no failure attached. The dream you no longer want is data about who you're becoming, not a target you missed."

Inside the dream session: Debrief the wall first ("who hit the wall at 40? what came up after?") so the wall is a shared story, not a private failure. For whoever did not reach forty, the wall was wherever their list stopped; the wall is the shared story, never the number. Then go around once, in order, the same way the morning circle goes: each is invited to share one dream, aloud or by putting it on the tribe dreams wall, starting with a within-12-months one, and pass is a complete answer. The wall is a second way to share for anyone, not a side door: a dream pinned there has been shared the same as one said aloud, and the guide reads the wall aloud once so the whole room hears all of it. Watch the lists grow live as dreams prove contagious. As they share, you begin to hold each learner's dreams with them, which is what makes you a coach and not a teacher. Ask before you work one - "do you want to just say that one, or do you want us to think about how you'd live it?" - and follow the answer. The circle's held-or-worked rule runs here too, and this is the first week the room learns it on something light. A warm catch-up in the walk-in, never in front of the room, for anyone whose list stopped early. Nobody leaves ashamed of a count.

The settle and the closing minute: Open every guide day with the settle. Teach the closing minute at its youngest register this session, and use it at each day's close. On the day, "take your closing minute" is the whole prompt; the three questions are the learner's own, in the fixed words from Part 1. Spoken, never written for the studio.

Watch-fors: Do not let the region map read as a deficit ledger - the quiet regions are invitations, not gaps. Keep the credit and path conversation out of day one entirely; belonging roots first. The permission to dream is genuine, so protect it from any quiet "be realistic."

What you'll need: The take-home 100 Dreams card (the rule, the wall at 40, a spark bank of warm words, "borrowed dreams count," "what did you want when you were eight?", and "kept however you keep your Log"). Blank Captain's Logs in several forms. The five-region prompt map. A tribe dreams wall surface. The exit-ramp place, set up before Tuesday. One shared task to carry the week. Cards for agreement contributions. The map of the year to hand out. The two names, written: the one adult outside the room, and the person who takes the baby. After the first year, notice which words on the card nobody used, and change them: a skipped door is a dead label.

Session 2 - The Lineage (five weeks, Sep 20 - Oct 21)

What it's for: to gather the stories of where you come from, and to see that an ordinary life carries enormous meaning.

For the learner: You come from somewhere and someone. This session you learn how to gather a story - how to interview someone who made you and listen for the story under the facts - and you bring what you choose of it to a family-story potluck. "Where you come from" is answered whatever your roots are: interrupted, mixed, adopted, chosen, unknown, or forward-facing. Interrupted lineage is still lineage. However you arrive, you belong at this table.

This session goes near death. You interview someone older than you, usually much older, about a life further along than yours. The room also listens to a recording of real people telling their life stories, and one of them is dying. People get sick, people are gone, people are not speaking to each other, and all of that lives in family stories. Some of it will be yours. You will know in advance, every time, before anything heavy starts. There is a named place to step out to and you never owe a reason for going there. And if your own lineage holds something you do not want to go near, you can do this whole session without going near it.

The ask itself has a ceiling and a floor. **One interview, once** - that is the ceiling, and nobody is asked for a second. The person you ask is told, by you, what this is for and where their story will go, and they can take any of it back at any point, even after they have told you. After the interview there is one more thing, and it is not a second interview: you may take what you made of it back to them and go through it with them, so they can hear it and take anything out. That is for them, not for us, and you can skip it. And you may decline the ask entirely. Some people will have good reason: a family they are not in contact with, a story they already know they do not want opened, or simply no. Declining the interview is not declining the

session. The session's question is where do you come from, and "I am not asking anyone" is one of its true answers.

The flow:

Weeks 5-9 · Sep 20 - Oct 21 · off: Mon Oct 11, Indigenous Peoples' Day / Columbus Day - see watch-fors

One ask. This is a cap, not a guideline. Each learner interviews one person, once. Five weeks, and most of them go to the **waiting**, not to more asking: a learner asks a grandmother on a Tuesday and the answer comes when it comes, after a phone call across time zones, after a cousin is consulted, after an old woman decides whether she wants to tell it. Fewer weeks would force the ask and the return into one breath. A second, deeper ask is the line where gathering becomes excavation, and we do not cross it.

The elder has a no, and they are told so. They are the one person in this arc who did not enrol here, who consented to a grandchild rather than a curriculum. Before the interview they are told plainly what it is for and where the story will go. Where the story will go means all of it: the potluck table, and anything the learner writes or makes this year that carries the elder's words. They may withdraw anything, at any point, **including after the telling**, and a withdrawal reaches that far too: what is taken back comes out of what was written and out of anything made from it. The learner carries that sentence to them; it is not ours to assume.

- **Week 5 (open, re-thread).** A short re-thread first: where were you, where are you now, what came back changed over the break. The three dreams chosen in week 4 have had a break to rest - some will have shifted, and that is data, not drift. Then open the session: family is who made you. Name the safety net and the other honest ways in *first*, warmly, so everyone knows they belong before anything is asked - **and make that door visible to the whole room in week one, not produced later for whoever needs it.** A door that appears only when someone needs it announces them for needing it. For some learners the silence, the rupture or the migration *is* the lineage, and the structure says so before anyone asks. The family tree as stories, not a chart. Preview the recording of real people talking about their own dying - name that it touches death and loss, and give a real place to step out to. Then the craft: how to interview someone who made you, how to listen for the story under the facts ("what was that time like for you?" not "when were you born?"). Practice in pairs in the room first. Give them the words to carry to the person they ask, before they ask anything:

> SAY
>
> "Before you ask them anything, tell them what it's for and where it goes. Something like: 'I'm gathering a story about where I come from, for my studio. Some of it goes to a meal with my people there, and some of it might end up in what I write or make this year. Anything you tell me, you can take back - now, later, or after I've written it down.' Then they know their no is real before they've said a word."

The ask goes out at the end of the week.

- **Week 6 (the fallow week - and it stays empty).** No new lineage content. **This is the year's one deliberately empty stretch inside the arc, and it is un-harvested: no Work of the Day, nothing reported, nothing to hand in.** The temptation to refill it the first time it looks idle is the exact thing it exists to resist. Low-stakes in-studio craft only, if anything at all. The guide's work this week is the walk-in, for whoever wants to say where the ask stands: sent, answered, still waiting, or not made. "Not made" closes the question, and nobody is asked it twice. Nobody is behind. **Waiting is the relationship, not a gap before it.**
- **Week 7 (gather).** They bring back what they gathered. Voluntary share of one surprising thing. Reflect the meaning under the facts - a recipe as a story, an ordinary day as a whole world. **Debrief the ask, never the elder.** What did you do, what would you try - never what they withheld. A characterisation of an absent family member, said aloud to six peers who will never meet them, is not the learner's to make, and the learner will sit across a table from this person again.
- **Week 8 (apply).** Prepare the short telling that goes with each dish (or with no dish at all). **Then offer the return, and it is not a second gathering.** The learner may take what they made of it back to the elder and go through it with them: *did I get this right, is there anything you want taken out?* That hands the elder power instead of asking for more. It is offered and declinable, never a station anyone is marched through, and whatever they add unprompted is theirs to give. Set the potluck together. (The Oct 11 holiday removes this week's Monday; see the watch-fors.)
- **Week 9 (harvest).** The family-story potluck gets its own week and its own body, rather than riding the back of a working day. The table is the tribe, the guide, and whoever each learner chooses to invite - the person you interviewed is welcome at it, and is told so when you ask them. **Build the vessel to receive an empty hand:** "I asked, and the answer has not come yet" is a true telling about lineage. If the table cannot hold that, the rite shames the learner it was built for. Ask the pace question as the week closes - is the plan still matching

the speed your real life is running at? - and on the last guided day run the closing minute at session scale, before the break. Bridge to The Power of Choice.

Things to say:

> SAY
>
> "Family is who made you - biological, chosen, or found. A grandparent, a mentor, a coach, a sibling, a neighbor. Whoever left a mark."

> SAY
>
> "Your lineage is also who you choose, who you're building, who you're becoming. You can be the first of a line. That's a full front door, not a side exit."

> SAY
>
> "A recipe you wish you had, recreated from memory, is as real an offering as one that's been handed down for generations."

> SAY
>
> "You choose how much of your story travels to the table - all of it, a little, or none. You're never the exhibit."

> SAY
>
> "This recording touches death and loss. Here's where you can step out to, and you don't owe anyone a reason."

The settle and the closing minute: Carry the settle, and go further down the safety floor than usual - grief opens for some this session, so use a short way down in the middle of the work and the close-return on the deep days. Close with the three prompts. Important: real grief is **not** a costume anyone takes off at the end. This is a "that was me, and I carry it, and I'm still here" close, never a "that wasn't me" one. If an opening runs deeper than a close can hold, hand off warmly to the referral pathway.

Watch-fors: The mortality preview is the sharpest safety point - preview it, name the content, give a real exit, honor opt-out with no explanation. The family interview can surface rupture (estrangement, loss, unknown parents); keep the other honest ways in visible, not buried. Name specific peoples (Eritrean, Nepali, Basque, Diné), never a regional lump. And the

learner's own word for their people is the word; the guide never asks for a finer-grained one. At the potluck, protect the material-poverty path: the studio-provided base dish can quietly *be* a learner's contribution, pre-arranged so a learner who brings nothing is indistinguishable from one who brought a dish. Presence, not provision. A learner from a marginalized or painful lineage sets their own terms and is never turned into a lesson for the room. **The Monday Oct 11 holiday falls inside this session.** Decide its observance given the studio's values, and decide what the studio calls it: the federal calendar names it Columbus Day, and this programme's values point to Indigenous Peoples' Day. It lands on a self-run Monday, so the decision is about the name and the framing rather than the schedule. In a session about lineage, the name is not a small question. If the studio names it Indigenous Peoples' Day, name the specific peoples whose homelands the studio stands on, in the names those nations use for themselves, confirmed from their own published materials - never "the local tribes." The rule about specific peoples applies to the book.

What you'll need: The recording about dying, previewed, with its transcript and a real exit space. Interview-skill practice prompts. The elder's sentence, written so the learner can carry it word for word: what this is for, where the story will go, and that they may take anything back, at any point, including afterwards. The other honest ways in, named as equal from day one. The referral pathway, live - this is the first session that hands off to it. Potluck logistics with the inclusion floor (base meal provided, no cover charge, allergen and cultural and religious safe, presence not consumption). The exit ramp, named for the potluck room and shown before guests arrive - the same no-reason rule holds at a feast.

Session 3 - The Power of Choice (three weeks, Nov 1 - Nov 18, ends into Thanksgiving)

What it's for: to make choosing a muscle you can feel in your body.

For the learner: You cannot always choose what happens to you. But the space between what happens and what you do next - that space is where your whole freedom lives. Every guide morning this session opens with a fork: one small real decision, about three minutes, no winner, nothing scored, nothing written down. The same shape every time, on purpose, because that is how a thing stops being an exercise and starts being something your body knows how to do. Then you notice the choices you have been making by not choosing. Responsibility, freedom, and choice are one knot, not three topics. And decline-with-reasoning - the way "no" works here - is this exact power, practiced on us: your no stands the moment

you say it, and the reasoning you bring to your tribe afterwards is this same muscle, used on purpose.

A session about choice can do damage if it is taken too far, so: **not everything is a choice.** Some things happen to you. Some things were done to you that you did not choose, and nothing in this session says otherwise. Nobody here is going to tell you that you chose your circumstances, and nobody is going to tell you that you chose anything that was done to you. The choosing we practice is what you do next. That is a different thing, and it is the only thing we are claiming.

And one more honest thing, about right now rather than about the past. **Some of you have more room to choose than others do.** Who decides where you live, whether you work, whether a Saturday is yours - that is not the same for everyone in this room, and it is not a measure of anything about you. So: the smallest real choice counts here. A choice made inside a tight constraint is the same muscle as a choice made with the whole field open, and sometimes it is the harder rep. Nobody is asked to bring a big one.

And a warning. Getting better at choosing on purpose sometimes makes things louder at home before it makes them easier. That is not you doing it wrong. We break for Thanksgiving right after this session. The guide is not reachable over the break - that is their rest too - but the one adult outside the room is, the same as always, and so is 988. If something at home gets hard because of work you did here, that is exactly the kind of thing to call about.

The flow:

> *Weeks 10-12 · Nov 1 - Nov 18 · six guide days in total: Tue Nov 2, Thu Nov 4, Tue Nov 9, Thu Nov 11, Tue Nov 16, Thu Nov 18 · two of them are federal holidays - Election Day, Tue Nov 2, the session's first guided morning, and Veterans Day, Thu Nov 11 - and observance is decided before the session opens, not during it · ends into Thanksgiving*

Settle the guide-day count before you plan the weeks. This is a three-week session whose opening ritual is daily, and the number of guided mornings it actually has is either six, five, or four depending on the holiday call. At five, which is the shape the companion grid is written to, the week that loses a day is week 11. Make the call, then read the grid.

- **Week 10 (open, re-thread).** On the first guided day, the re-thread first, short - where were you, where are you now, what came back changed - and the potluck telling is the natural thing to pick back up; it has had a week to settle. Then the fork, the way it will open every guided morning from here. Then the knot: responsibility, freedom, and choice as one thing.

Name the honest frame up front, including the part about room (see watch-fors). On the second guided day, the first story at a safe distance - in a story, a film, a moment in history - "where did one choice change everything?" Small weight first; the heavy ones are later or not at all. Then, only for those who wish, in their own life.

- **Week 11 (deepen).** The fork to open. Then, kept light and personal: a choice opens some doors and quietly closes others; there is no free move. Then the turn toward agency - defaults and drift, the choices you make by not choosing. Notice your own patterns without judgment, and **go first yourself**: name one of your own defaults out loud, a real one, before anyone is asked for theirs. **If Veterans Day is observed, this week has one guided morning**, and the doors-and-defaults work runs on it alone. Pick the half you keep rather than compressing both; defaults is the half that feeds week 12. This is also the week with the longest stretch between asks, so the walk-in question matters most here.
- **Week 12 (apply, then harvest).** Each learner names a real choice in front of them, **or one they are still circling**, and practices choosing it deliberately - weighing it, owning it, feeling agency in the body. Circling is a real answer at fifteen and at eighteen; a learner pushed to land a choice on a Tuesday has been handed a deadline, not a freedom. Then the harvest: name, if you wish, a choice you now own, or say that none is owned yet - seeing where you have not been choosing is itself a harvest - and the shift from "things just happen to me" to "things happen, and then I choose." Ask the pace question here too: three weeks is short, and the plan should still match the speed that is real for you. Bridge to Running My Own Ship. **On the last guided day, Thu Nov 18, before the ten-day gap:** run the closing minute at session scale. For the learner whose choice-work opened friction at home, Thanksgiving is where the work meets the people it is about. Send them into it held, not loose. Before they go, say all three out loud: how to reach the one adult outside the room over the break; that 988 is always open, any hour; and that you are not reachable. Their page already says the third one. Hearing it from you the day before makes it a plan rather than a surprise.

Things to say:

> SAY
>
> "You can't always choose what happens, and sometimes what happens leaves no room to choose at all. What you do next, once there is room again - that part is yours. That's the whole of it, and it's enough."

> SAY
>
> "Some of your defaults were handed to you. Noticing one isn't blaming yourself for it - it's just turning the light on."

> SAY
>
> "Not 'what should I do?' handed to me. 'Here's how I'm deciding.' That's yours."

> SAY
>
> "Some of you have more room than others do right now. The smallest real choice counts, and a choice made inside a tight constraint is the same muscle. Nobody has to bring a big one."

The forks (the daily opener, and the five rules that make it one): The opener is **one fixed form, run the same way every guided morning**, not a rotating set. The fixed form is the Fork: pose one small real choice, they choose, then trace together what the choice opened and what it quietly closed. The sameness is the point. A different exercise each morning builds tolerance for novelty; the same one, five mornings running, builds the thing this session is named for. The other forms in the bank are a second, optional slot on some days, never a substitute for the opener.

Five rules hold for every fork, and they are what keep a daily ritual from becoming a daily test:

1. **A ceiling.** About three minutes. No winner, no score, nothing kept, never twice in one morning. If it is running hot, it ends early.
2. **No consequence the guide hands out.** The consequence traced is the one the chooser names. A fork whose outcome the adult dispenses teaches the opposite of the session.
3. **A way to be in it without speaking, built in rather than permitted beside it.** Every fork has a pointed, written, or placed way to answer. A fork that needs a quick voice or a quick read is a fork somebody sits out of, and in a daily ritual that somebody gets seen sitting out five times.
4. **No tradeoff that assumes resources.** "Would you rather" with options that cost money, travel, or a free Saturday is a fork the learner with the least room cannot honestly play. Keep the stakes inside what every learner in the room actually holds.

5. **Nobody is asked to improvise in front of the room.** A learner who freezes in a scene has just been shown, publicly, that they cannot choose, in the session about choosing. Freeze is not a choice. Any form with a performance edge is offered to volunteers or not at all.

The bank, the weight-graded story ladder, and the day-by-day grid live in the companion: `launch-pad-session-3-forks-and-stories-v0.1.md`.

The settle and the closing minute: Settle to open, then the fork. Close with the three prompts. **On any morning the fork runs hot, take the way down after it** rather than only after the deep block - this session's activation is fast and upward rather than heavy, and an activated room cannot hear the knot. The gladness we hope for here is play; for many people agency feels good in the body, and for some it feels like risk before it feels like freedom. Both are true, and the second one is why the ceiling and the non-speaking door exist.

Watch-fors: This is the load-bearing safety point: a session about agency can wound if it implies *everything* is a choice. It is not. Some things happen to a person; some people have had choice taken from them. Never "you chose your circumstances," never "you chose your harm." Always distinguish choices you made from things that happened to you. **And the present-tense version of the same care: the learners do not have equal room.** A session about choosing, run without that said out loud, quietly teaches the learner with the least that agency belongs to other people. It is on their page now; say it in the room too. **Go first on defaults.** For a sixteen-year-old, the default in the room is set by the nearest adult's face, so name one of your own defaults, badly, before you ask. The walk-in is where you hear whether home got louder. Ask it there, one learner at a time, never in the circle, and ask it on every guided morning of week 11 and week 12. Keep consequence-thinking light - deep second- and third-order work belongs to a later year; here it stays personal and immediate. **Two holidays fall on guide days inside this three-week session: Election Day, Tue Nov 2, and Veterans Day, Thu Nov 11.** Decide observance of both before the session opens, not during it. The session has six guide days in total, so observing both leaves four, which is a change to the plan rather than a detail. Election Day can be framed as a civics moment if it is kept.

What you'll need: The companion: the fork bank with its ceilings, the three-rung story ladder, and the guide-day grid. One named story chosen per guided morning, never two, and never the heaviest rung first. A pointed or written way to answer every fork. Opt-out held open all session; the referral pathway ready. The holiday call made and the grid read against it.

Session 4 - Running My Own Ship (three weeks, Nov 29 - Dec 16, ends into the winter break)

What it's for: to build a routine that actually fits you - the thing that makes freedom possible instead of just noise.

For the learner: Freedom you can't hold is just noise. A routine that fits you is how you actually run your own ship. This is Session 3's power of choice, lived as a rhythm - one that fits *you*, not one imposed on you. Routine is not the opposite of freedom. It is what makes freedom possible. This session you build a routine that survives a bad day, you practice real communication, and you look back at who you are becoming.

One thing your routine has to have in it: **your Vineyard.** A week with no time in it for something you love is not a finished routine, and we will send you back to it the same way we would if you had forgotten to sleep. That is the one place this programme is strict about joy. Strict means we keep asking whether the time is there. It never means we check what you did with it, and if you refuse this part too, you will still hear the question - that is the one thing you cannot get us to stop. What goes in the time stays nobody's business but yours.

The flow:

> *Weeks 13-15 · Nov 29 - Dec 16 · ends into the winter break*

December runs lighter by design - short dark days, the guide's own hardest stretch. This session is December, entirely. Postpone depth freely and protect your own fallow.

- **Week 13 (open, re-thread). Open the first guided day (Tue Nov 30) with the re-thread, before anything else:** where were you, where are you now, what came back changed. Then the reframe: routine makes freedom possible. Begin designing your own routine (not a template imposed on you). Then time management as craft - time-blocking, energy management (when are *you* sharp?), and the Weekly Plan as the real tool. Design a routine that survives a bad day, not just a good one.
- **Week 14 (deepen, then apply).** Communication foundations - real listening, "I" statements, asking a question worth answering (this feeds the interviewing through-skill and, later, mentor outreach). Then a real communication: draft and send a genuine email to an adult, prepare a needed conversation, or present a plan to the room. Refine your routine from two weeks of running it - what bent, what held.

- **Week 15 (apply, then harvest). This week holds the true midpoint of the year, and the midpoint is the winter break itself** - the fold between here and January, crossed with the learner's body out of the room. So the crossing comes in two halves. **This half, on Thu Dec 16:** the look-back across Sessions 1 to 4 (who are you becoming?), the pace question, the re-ask (*is this still yours?*), and the re-entry note to your future self so the throughline survives two weeks away. Ask the re-ask to the room; take the answers one at a time, in the walk-in or at the Table, never round the circle. A yes said in front of six people is not the answer you asked for. A no, or an I don't know, is held the way Part 2 holds any no: received whole first, the door offered once, the learner kept inside the room while the plan changes around them. Then the harvest: name the routine that now fits you, or name honestly that it does not fit yet - a routine still bending is a real harvest in December - and share (voluntary) one thing the look-back showed you. They carry the re-ask through two weeks of ordinary life and come back with evidence rather than a feeling the circle produced. This is the longest stretch of the year with no one in the room. Say all three out loud: how to reach the one adult across the two weeks; that 988 is always open, any hour; and that you are not reachable until January. The referral pathway stays live the whole time, not only on program days. Then run the closing minute at session scale - this half of the crossing closes here. Bridge to The Full Draft.

Things to say:

> SAY
>
> "Routine isn't the opposite of freedom. It's what makes freedom possible. We're building one that fits *you*, not one that's imposed on you."

> SAY
>
> "What have these first weeks shown you about yourself? Who are you becoming?"

> SAY
>
> "What pace is real for you right now, and does the plan match it? That includes the credit plan."

> SAY
>
> "And the one I ask only a few times a year, so hear it as a real question: is this still yours? Being here, doing this. 'No' and 'I don't know' are both real answers, and you have two weeks to sit with it."

> SAY
>
> "A routine that fits you protects the fallow. The un-filled cup is part of the rhythm, not a gap to optimize away."

The settle and the closing minute: Settle to open; three prompts to close. The gladness we hope for is quiet - a clear desk, real momentum, the satisfaction of a rhythm that fits.

Watch-fors: This is the natural readiness moment - read each learner's readiness for more of their own hours with them, one learner at a time, never by date, and let them name how much scaffold they want. Some move toward more autonomy; some keep the full scaffold, and that never reads as remedial. The midpoint look-back is growth-framed, not a shortfall audit - "who you're becoming," not "what you didn't finish." Guard hard against it becoming a private ledger of falling short. The credit and path conversation is a pacing conversation, witnessed, never graded; a learner who needs a multi-year path names it now, adjusting the plan to the learner. Keep communication practice real (a genuine email, a genuine conversation), not role-play only.

What you'll need: The Weekly Plan tool. A real email or conversation for each learner to actually do. The Credit/Path Map for the pacing check. The re-entry note format. The long haul is next, so a routine that holds is exactly what a learner needs to carry the Full Draft through six unbroken weeks of January and February.

Session 5 - The Full Draft (six weeks, Jan 3 - Feb 10)

What it's for: to claim your whole life on the page - all of it - before you choose what to keep.

For the learner: You cannot shape a story you have not yet dared to tell in full. So first you write all of it - messy, complete, unedited, nothing too small. This is your whole life on the page. Some people feel real relief and catharsis in claiming it; some feel tired, flat, or unfinished. Both are true. No one is asked to perform the feeling. Being witnessed is a gift

here, never something you owe the room. What you write is private by default - it lives in your Captain's Log, which no one reads - and you choose what, if anything, you say aloud.

Here are the five things you will be asked to write. All of them, now, so none of them is a surprise on the day.

1. A moment after which you were not the same.
2. A place, a smell, a song, a meal, a room. Memory lives in the body before it lives in words.
3. The people who made you. Not just family. Anyone who left a mark.
4. Your worst day and your best day, and what each one taught you.
5. One ordinary day at an age you pick, start to finish.

Number four is the heavy one. It comes in the fifth week of this session rather than the first, and a week before it you will be asked, one to one and never in front of the room, whether you want the gentler version instead. The gentler version is a real option and not a lesser one. A hard thing can be named without being told in detail, and "here is what it taught me" is a complete answer. Nobody has to relive anything to belong here.

The flow (the five prompts, spread across six weeks):

> *Weeks 16-21 · Jan 3 - Feb 10 · off: Mon Jan 17, MLK Day · no break inside this session*

This session opens three days after a two-week holiday and then runs six unbroken weeks of interior work. No break falls inside it, so what a break would quietly do for a body, the design has to do on purpose.

- **Week 16 (open, re-thread) - no prompt.** The second half of the midpoint crossing, and it is the whole day, not a warm-up. The big re-thread: where were you, where are you, what came back changed. Then why the whole life first, and the relief some people find in getting it all down. **Name the safety floor aloud** - the exit ramp, the gentler-prompt swap, the referral pathway with a real room and a real person in it. No prompt this week.
- **Week 17 (deepen).** Prompt 1 - Turning points ("name a moment after which you were not the same"), on the second guided day. A recording of real people telling their life stories. Ask the pace question at the close, two clear weeks before the hard prompt so there is still time to act on the answer.
- **Week 18 (deepen).** Prompt 2 - Sensory doorways (a place, a smell, a song, a meal, a room; memory lives in the body before it lives in words). Memoir excerpts as models. *(MLK Monday removes a self-run day and its midday check-in.)*

- **Week 19 (deepen).** Prompt 3 - The people ("who made you? not just family - anyone who left a mark"). What someone told you in the autumn is theirs, and the autumn's rules still hold over it. What they were to you is yours, and nobody can take that back - including a person who took their own story back. **On the Thursday, an explicit readiness read for what is coming, taken in the walk-in, one learner at a time, never round the circle**, and the softer prompt offered in advance rather than in the moment. Offering it on the day it lands is too late for the learner who needs it.
- **Week 20 (apply: the hard prompt).** Prompt 4 - The hard and the best (the worst day, the best day, what each taught). Run it on the Tuesday, so the held day is the Thursday and no one carries the worst day alone into a weekend. This is the sharpest care point - run all four things in the settle and the closing minute below, and the gentler version was offered last Thursday. Follow it with a lighter, held day: coming-of-age songs as mirrors ("which line is about you?"), then back to their own words.
- **Week 21 (the lighter week, then harvest). Designed lighter on purpose, not by accident** - the week after the hard prompt carries no new hard ground. Prompt 5 - A slice of life ("write one ordinary day at age ___, start to finish" - a whole world in an ordinary day). The ordinary day is the decompression, not one more descent. Then push the draft toward whole, and the harvest: the full draft as it stands - complete, or not yet, or with prompts swapped or left out - being witnessed, sharing only what you choose. An unfinished draft is a real harvest. The pace question and the re-ask both come at the close, answered the same way as in December - after the whole life is on the page is the strongest re-ask of the year. **Run the closing minute at session scale before the break**, and the referral pathway stays live *through* Feb 11-20, not only on program days; the learner is told so. A learner finishes their whole life on the page and then no one sees them for ten days. Bridge to Chapter One.

Things to say:

> SAY
>
> "Write all of it - messy, complete, nothing too small. You can't shape a story you haven't yet dared to tell in full. If relief comes, it comes from getting it down, not from making it good."

> SAY
>
> "Your draft lives in your Log, so it takes whatever form your Log takes. A told draft, a drawn one, a typed one - all of it is the full draft."

> SAY
>
> "You choose what goes in the draft and what stays private. A hard thing can be named without being detailed - 'what it taught me' is enough. No one has to relive anything to belong here."

> SAY
>
> "A gentler prompt is always available. You can swap any prompt for a softer one, anytime, no reason owed."

> SAY
>
> "Wherever you went just now, that's exactly what the closing minute is for. Take it, the whole minute, and go for the real answer. Nothing you find in it is for me."

> SAY
>
> "The break starts Friday and runs ten days. I won't be reachable - that's my rest too - but the person you can go to is, the whole time, not only on studio days, and 988 never closes. You just put your whole life on a page; here is how to reach them."

The settle and the closing minute: This is the anchor session for both. On every writing day, four things, every time:

- **The settle** to open.
- **A short way down between hard passages.** Thirty seconds: feet on the floor, look around the room, one breath.
- **The close-return** at the end. Say it out loud so the body hears it: "That was then. This is now. Look around and name one thing you can see. You're in this room, and the hard part is behind you."
- **An exit ramp that is always open**, used without asking. A body that stays inside a worst-day memory for an unbroken hour floods. The closing minute lands hardest here and rides *into* the private Log. This is a "that was me, and I carry it, and I'm still here" close, and real grief is never something a learner is asked to put down at the door. When a close meets something bigger than a close can hold, hand off warmly to the referral pathway. Open no faster than you teach a person to close; this session is where that rule is most literally true.

Watch-fors: This is the heaviest session, and it has a **binding gate.** The pathway was built before the year opened (Part 2) and Session 2 already leaned on it; this is where you check it again and certify it in writing before anyone writes a worst day. Do not run this session with a real learner until both of these are true:

1. **The referral pathway built before the year opened is still real today.** The quiet space is still a real room. The named clinician still has a current number and will still take the call. Your own honest limit is said out loud again. The clinical hand-off is in place. And the second pair of hands for the baby is re-confirmed for a January morning, not a September one.
2. **A consented safety walk is done, and it walked this session's floor.** Someone who has held this kind of work with teenagers - a licensed clinician or an experienced guide - has walked this session's plan with you, in person, before any learner meets it: the settle, the way down, the close-return, the exit ramp and the hand-off, not only Session 1's morning.

Who certifies this gate: you do, in writing, dated, on the plan - naming the quiet space, naming the clinician, and naming the date of the walk and who walked it. A solo studio has no second signature available, so say plainly that the guide self-certifies and make the certification a written thing rather than a feeling. A gate nobody signs is a gate nobody holds. A trauma-informed floor with an unbuilt trap door is not yet trauma-informed. Coach, not therapist: you hold the container and witness; you do not treat. Every session opens with a re-thread; Session 4's is short and this one is a whole day. The two-week winter gap is the highest risk to a learner's throughline, which is why week 16 carries no prompt. Being witnessed is a gift, never a demand.

What you'll need: The five scaffolding prompts. The recordings and readings (the Session 2 recording of real people telling their life stories, previewed again if it is played again; memoir excerpts; coming-of-age songs; each with a transcript or an audio form). Gentler swap-prompts on hand. The built referral pathway and the designated quiet space. Your gate certification, written and dated, before week 16.

Session 6 - Chapter One (six weeks, Feb 21 - Mar 30)

What it's for: to become the author of your own story, and to learn that shaping it small is not making your life small - it is declaring there are chapters to come.

For the learner: A chapter is not a smaller version of your life. It is a shaped thing with one thread running all the way through, and you learn to find the thread. To you, right now, this *is*

your whole life - so we don't argue with that, we flip it. Calling it "Chapter One" is an act of hope: it declares there are chapters coming. It doesn't make your life small. It makes your future big. And here is the discipline that keeps this from feeling like loss: we never cut to hide. We cut to focus. Everything you leave out of Chapter One is kept, in the full draft, in your Log. It is still true. It just isn't load-bearing for *this* chapter's shape.

The flow (five steps of shaping, across six weeks):

> *Weeks 22-27 · Feb 21 - Mar 30 · off: Mon Feb 21, Presidents Day (the session's first day)*

- **Week 22 (open, re-thread).** A short re-thread first, then: become the author; a chapter is a shaped thing with a throughline; introduce the "Chapter One = hope" reframe. Go back through the full draft. That is a re-opening, so this day runs Session 5's four things - settle, the way down, the close-return, the exit ramp - and any passage may be skipped in the going-back without a word.
- **Week 23 (deepen: the truth-discipline).** Cut to focus, never to hide; everything cut is kept in the Log, still true. Practice the discipline on a shared example at a safe distance before turning it on their own life. If an elder's words from the Lineage are in your chapter, their no still reaches here: anything they asked to take back comes out of what travels, even now, and stays only in your Log if you want it kept.
- **Week 24 (deepen: the throughline).** Shaping step 1: find the thread ("what is this chapter *about*?" - one sentence). You hold the question; the learner finds the line. A throughline that is theirs tends to land as relief rather than a cage. If it lands as a cage, hold the question longer, not the line.
- **Week 25 (deepen: the load-bearing moments).** *Ask the pace question at the close, two weeks before the session ends while there is still time to act on it.* Shaping step 2: choose the three to five moments that hold the chapter up - the ones that set up who you are becoming. *Keep, because* - never *cut, because.* Everything else moves, honored, into the Log; nothing is lost.
- **Week 26 (apply: write it).** Shaping step 3: make Chapter One - tight, shaped, true. Revision as care; share a passage with the room if you want to.
- **Week 27 (harvest: the second distillation, and the turn outward).** Shaping steps 4 and 5: distill the same life into a second shape, the short story-of-self and the one-page resume. Same material, two forms - a story (meaning) and a page (practical), for two different rooms. A Chapter One not yet finished, or a thread not yet found, is a real harvest - the shaping goes on. **Assemble the portfolio here** - it belongs in the join between the two

sessions, not to a day of its own. **Choose the medium for your This Is Me piece now, before the break, if it's ready**, so the choice has two weeks to sit; the scarce thing in the last session is not making time but dwell time. An unchosen medium crosses the break too, and nothing in Session 7 waits on it. Name the four ways of being seen alongside it, equal, so no one meets them for the first time in April. **And the turn outward starts here, not in Session 7.** Twelve weeks have gone inward; the coming-back-out needs more than the final stretch to carry it, so this harvest turns the work toward being seen. Ask the pace question as the session closes: four weeks remain, so the plan can still bend to the speed that is real for you. Run the closing minute at session scale before the break. Bridge to the Unveiling.

Things to say:

> SAY
>
> "Calling this 'Chapter One' isn't shrinking your life. It's declaring there are chapters coming. It doesn't make your life small - it makes your future big."

> SAY
>
> "We never cut to hide. We cut to focus. What you leave out isn't erased - it's kept in your Log, still true. It just isn't load-bearing for this chapter."

> SAY
>
> "Keep this, because . ***Not cut this, because*** . Choose your keepers by what they set up in who you're becoming."

> SAY
>
> "Your resume is a tool that belongs to you. One true page inside your portfolio, for the rooms you choose to walk into. It isn't you, reduced to a page."

The settle and the closing minute: Settle to open; the three prompts to close - the shaping *is* a re-crossing of the whole draft. Memory is still in play here (it draws on the Session 5 draft), so keep opt-out and the coach-not-therapist boundary live.

Watch-fors: Offer the hero's-journey arc as *one* map, not the frame. The learner whose life is a garden, a spiral, or a set of rooms authors their own shape with equal honor. The learner is the author of their story, never a character in ours. The truth-discipline is the safety - cutting one's own life can feel like erasure, and the kept-in-the-Log reframe is what makes it authorship.

Hold the "Chapter One = hope" reframe whenever the shrinking starts to feel like loss. Sharing a passage is an offer, never a round. If it starts going in order, stop it once, warmly: this is an offer, not a round, and a passage kept to yourself is still Chapter One.

What you'll need: The full drafts from Session 5. A shared safe-distance example to practice the cut-to-focus discipline. The one-page resume format, framed as a tool the learner owns. Portfolio materials.

Session 7 - This Is Me / The Unveiling (four weeks, Apr 10 - May 4)

What it's for: to declare who you are - dreamed in Session 1, drafted in Session 5, shaped in Session 6, now shown to your people.

For the learner: This is the year's harvest. You make a self-portrait - a "This Is Me" piece - in whatever medium is true to you: art, film, music, writing, spoken word, a practice, a set of values. It does not have to be a story. You present it with your portfolio, your resume page, and your Chapter One. Some people feel deeply seen; some feel exposed or flat. Both are honored, and no one performs the feeling. The audience is warm - your people, not a panel. It is a feast, not a judged presentation.

You choose how you are seen, and you know all the choices now rather than in April. Four ways, equal, not one main road and three exits:

- show your piece at the feast, with families there;
- show it to the tribe only;
- show it to one person you choose;
- make it in a form the guide, or a person you choose, presents for you while you sit with your people, or while you do not.

Nobody will ever have to ask for one of these; all four are offered to everyone, the same way. And "I have nothing to declare this year" is a real and honored harvest too. A flat year, a tired year, or an unfinished piece has not failed anything.

One more rule we hold for you. Afterwards people will want to talk to you about your piece, and **you do not have to answer any question about it, from anyone, including an adult who means well.** "I'd rather not say" is a complete answer that night, and the guide will back you on it in the room.

The flow:

Weeks 28-31 · Apr 10 - May 4 · the session break falls before this session (Apr 3-6), not inside it

- **Week 28 (open, re-thread).** A re-thread after the break, then open with a witness beat *first*: before you turn to your own portrait, witness someone else's story. Reflect a peer's Chapter One back to them **if that peer offers it to you**, or sit with one of the year's recordings of a real person telling their own life and reflect that teller's thread back - to the guide, or to the room if you choose. Nobody interviews anyone this session; the one interview of the year was in the autumn, and it stays one. Nobody's Chapter One is handed to a classmate by the guide. Pair this only where both learners have said yes, and the learner who is not in a pair that week witnesses a recorded life instead, which is equal rather than second. Done that way, being seen becomes reciprocal rather than performative. Then: what the Unveiling is, and the year it completes, and the four ways of being seen, named again as equal, so the choice is open the whole session. For most, the medium was chosen at the close of Session 6, so the making can begin on the first day; for anyone still choosing, the first week is the choosing, and that is not behind. It need not be a narrative.
- **Week 29 (deepen).** Make the piece (the guide is coach, not critic - the piece is theirs). Sharing works-in-progress is ambient, whenever someone wants it, not a scheduled beat. Refining is part of making, not a separate pass. *(The portfolio was assembled in Session 6. Any remaining logistics live on the self-run days.)*
- **Week 30 (apply).** Finish the piece. Confirm each learner's unveiling shape now, in the walk-in - the four were on the table from the first day, and this is the week the choice is made real, not first offered. Then the works-in-progress share **becomes** the dry run in the shape they chose: to the tribe, in the safety of the tribe, for those who chose it; with the one chosen person, or with the guide, for those who did not. Each is the same dry run, the rehearsal rather than a thing that precedes one. Prepare the exhibition together; hold any nerves warmly.
- **Week 31 (harvest).** Final touches and final rehearsal early in the week, then the Unveiling feast midweek, an afternoon or evening with a real audience (families, the tribe), each learner unveiling as much as they choose. **The year-close gets the last guided day, Thu May 4, to itself, not the feast's last hour** - the co-authoring review, the Log handoff ("it's yours; it goes where you say; no copy kept"), and the closing minute at year scale. This is also the last honest place to ask *is this still yours?*, answered the same way as in December. Then Open Waters.

Things to say:

SAY

"Before you turn to your own portrait, witness someone else's. If a friend offers you their Chapter One, reflect it back to them. A room where everyone has done some of the seeing is a safer room to be seen in."

SAY

"Your piece can be anything true to you - an image, a film, a song, a set of values, a practice. It doesn't have to be a story."

SAY

"The tribe is your people. A mentor, a friend's family who takes you in for the night - a chosen witness is honored exactly as much as anyone. You will not fall through this."

SAY

"This is the end of the first year of three. It's allowed to be a little tender. The story continues - next year, we ask what's worth solving."

The year-close: On the last guided day, after the feast has had its own night, three acts. First, a co-authoring close: the learner reviews the year's design *with* you, the design named not hidden - "here's how this year was built, and why; tell me what to change for your next year." The learner's call on their own year, never a feedback form, and declinable like every other quest; a learner who doesn't want to redesign the year has still closed it. Alongside it, put the whole short record of them on the table, unasked: attendance, pace, credit plan, any safety note. They could read it any day; this is the day you offer it. Second, the Captain's Log ownership handoff: the Log is theirs; it goes where they say - home, or back to the one place here only they open for next year - and no copy is kept. That is the same whatever form the Log took: if any of it lives on a studio device or in a scribe's hand, it goes to the learner and nothing stays behind. Third, the closing minute at year scale, below. The year ends on the learner owning their own record, not the studio archiving it.

The settle and the closing minute: The Unveiling turns a learner outward. Showing yourself to a room is its own kind of opening, so it needs its own private close. On the year-close day, after the feast, run the closing minute at the scale of the whole year, in its fixed words:

> SAY
>
> "Before the next year opens, take your closing minute at the whole year's scale. What did you meet this year? What do you carry back? What's different in you now - even a little? 'I don't know yet' is a real answer."

That is what brings a learner back from being on stage to being themselves. Then a real fallow stretch before the next year opens. Never start a new opening on a body still buzzing from the feast.

Watch-fors: Being seen is invitational, and being seen can be exposing, especially for the anxious or isolated learner. Offer the other three shapes as real roads, not as "share less": unveil to the tribe only, or in a form you present for them, or to one chosen person - each equal, not a lesser path. The learner with no family in the room is the one most exposed by "show your people," so name and hold them: the tribe *is* their people, and a chosen witness is honored equally, never as consolation. Do not let "families come" become a floor that learner falls through on the year's most tender day. Hold the year's close gently; this is a year-close, not a goodbye - the full Launch is a later year. Coach-not-therapist still applies; the piece can surface a lot.

What you'll need: Materials for many mediums. The witness-beat setup (peer reflection by consent, or the year's recordings of real people telling their lives). The feast planned like a real event with the inclusion floor (base provided, presence not consumption, allergen-safe). The exit ramp, named for the feast room and shown before families arrive - the same no-reason rule holds at a feast. The co-authoring review structure. The Log handoff.

Part 4 - Closing the year

The Unveiling harvest

The Unveiling is the year's culminating feast, and it deserves real weight and real warmth. It sits outside the daily morning grid - likely an afternoon or evening with families. Plan it like any studio feast, with the full inclusion floor: the base is always provided, no one watches a plate, everyone is allergen-safe, and presence matters more than what anyone brought. Each learner shows their "This Is Me" piece, their portfolio, and their Chapter One, as much as they choose to share. The whole point is being seen by your people in a room that is glad you exist.

Remember the honored empty outcome, here as everywhere: a learner who feels flat, or exposed, or unfinished has not failed the harvest. "I have nothing to declare this year" is a real and honored harvest. The fallow field is part of the crop.

The year-scale closing minute

The year opens with a felt beginning and closes with a public harvest - and a public harvest is itself an opening outward. So the year needs its private close, or the learner is left facing out with no way back in. It runs on the year-close day, the last guided day of Session 7, after the feast has had its own night. It is a naming, not a new ceremony: the practice they have run all year, put in their own hand at the year's scale. The words are in Session 7 and they do not change.

Then a real fallow stretch before the next year begins. Never walk a new year's opening on a body still activated from the last one. The learner who is staying needs this between-years close as much as a graduating learner needs the Launch - it is the arc-scale version of the practice they have run all year, put in their own hand.

The tail of the year: Open Waters

The flex tail runs May 8 to May 25, the three weeks after Session 7 closes on May 4. It is light structure, not a void: real-world expeditions, personal-project deep dives, high-school-credit close-out for anyone finishing the year's plan, and genuine fallow - rest is a legitimate use of it. Name it to families as intentional: flex plus fallow, not "we'll figure it out." And the bridge into the next year is one sentence: *"You know your story now. Next year: what is worth solving?"*

> *"We evoke - we never extract." - and that includes the guide, and everyone in the room.*

NOTES